The quaint mix of restraint and horror in the accounts of Burt and Cunningham might seem very Victorian to us today, but it is of a piece with modern Indian prudishness. Hindu conservatives mostly favour a sanitized, delimited and 'respectable' view of Hinduism without this 'shameful sex', which stains their idea of ancient Hindu glory. On Valentine's Day last year, the Hindu right group Bajrang Dal raged against even modest public displays of affection between couples—ironically in the name of tradition! In previous years, they've even protested the sale of the *Kamasutra* outside these temples. Some attribute this modern shift in attitudes towards sexuality to Hindu India's encounter with Muslims or Europeans. But as I'll argue, it has more to do with ideological fault lines within Hinduism itself. Suffice to say that Khajuraho's temple art sits uncomfortably in the modern Hindu imagination.

The temple art of Khajuraho, however, challenges and unsettles more than just the sexual prudes in modern culture, Victorian or Indian. It confronts our fundamental ideas and assumptions about art, aesthetics and 'proper' religious moods and sentiments. It challenges us to make sense of religious art that depicts not just heterosexual sex but also bestiality, masturbation, orgies, gang bangs, oral sex, lesbian and gay sex, exhibitionism and possibly even non-consensual or exploitative sex (one panel shows multiple men bearing weapons while having sex with a woman). The panels often depict aristocratic and royal men and women, as well as ascetics—bearded and clean-shaven, sometimes pot-bellied, wearing *rudraksha* beads and *kundala*s in their ears—participating, or just 'assisting', in these sexual acts. This is a far cry from the modern Hindu idea of moksha-pursuing ascetics. At times, even dancers and musicians turn up to heighten the erotic experience. Athletic poses are common and idealized youthful bodies are the norm.[3]

The walls of Khajuraho of course feature a lot more than erotic art, which accounts for less than 10 per cent of all sculptures. There are major and minor gods, often enacting scenes from various stories, in conventional roles or in amorous pairs. Mundane and secular subject matter abounds, such as *surasundari*s, or graceful young maidens, depicting 'common human moods, emotions and activities' like 'disrobing, yawning, scratching the back, touching the breasts, rinsing water from the wet plaits of hair,